# Connecting Heritage, Expanding Opportunities, Shaping a Shared Future.



# Foreword

Suriname occupies a distinctive position in South America, combining rich natural resources, cultural diversity and strategic access to the Caribbean and wider Latin American markets. As one of the continent's smaller economies, Suriname has significant potential across natural resources, mining, agriculture, energy, forestry, fisheries, tourism and emerging services. Its location on the northeastern coast of South America, together with its historical and cultural connections with Asia, provides a strong foundation for expanding international economic partnerships.

India and Suriname share a longstanding relationship marked by diplomatic goodwill, cultural connections and growing opportunities for economic cooperation. The presence of the Indian-origin community in Suriname has created a unique people-to-people bridge between the two countries, while bilateral engagement has increasingly expanded towards trade, investment, agriculture, healthcare, pharmaceuticals, information technology, renewable energy, capacity building and development cooperation. Suriname's growing economic opportunities and India's capabilities in technology, manufacturing, pharmaceuticals, infrastructure and services create considerable scope for mutually beneficial partnerships.

This Knowledge Paper examines Suriname's economic landscape, development priorities, key sectors and emerging opportunities, with particular emphasis on how CCI India can contribute to strengthening India–Suriname economic and business engagement. It presents a structured assessment of priority sectors, identifies relevant institutional and business stakeholders, and outlines practical avenues for trade promotion, investment facilitation, technology partnerships, business matchmaking and knowledge exchange.

The Knowledge Paper is intended to serve as a valuable reference for CCI India's engagement with the Government of Suriname, diplomatic missions, chambers of commerce, industry associations, investors and enterprises. Through sustained institutional engagement and focused sectoral cooperation, India and Suriname can unlock new avenues of economic partnership and build a stronger foundation for shared growth. CCI India can play a meaningful role in converting these opportunities into practical business outcomes and contributing to a deeper and more diversified India–Suriname economic relationship.



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# SURINAME

> Experience cultural diversity and natural beauty together



**Basic Facts, Demographics, and Monetary System:**

Suriname, officially the Republic of Suriname, is located on the northeastern Atlantic coast of South America and covers 163,820 sq. km, making it one of the smallest Its sovereign countries in the region.

Heritage site and the country's main urban center. Suriname has an estimated population of about 630,000 in 2024. It is the most culturally diverse nations, with Indo-Surinamese, Afro-Surinamese, Maroons, Indigenous Amerindians, Javanese, Chinese, and European communities. Dutch is the official language, and the national currency is the Surinamese Dollar (SRD), which has faced depreciation in recent years due to inflation and fiscal pressures.

**Economic Landscape and Gross Domestic Product (GDP)**

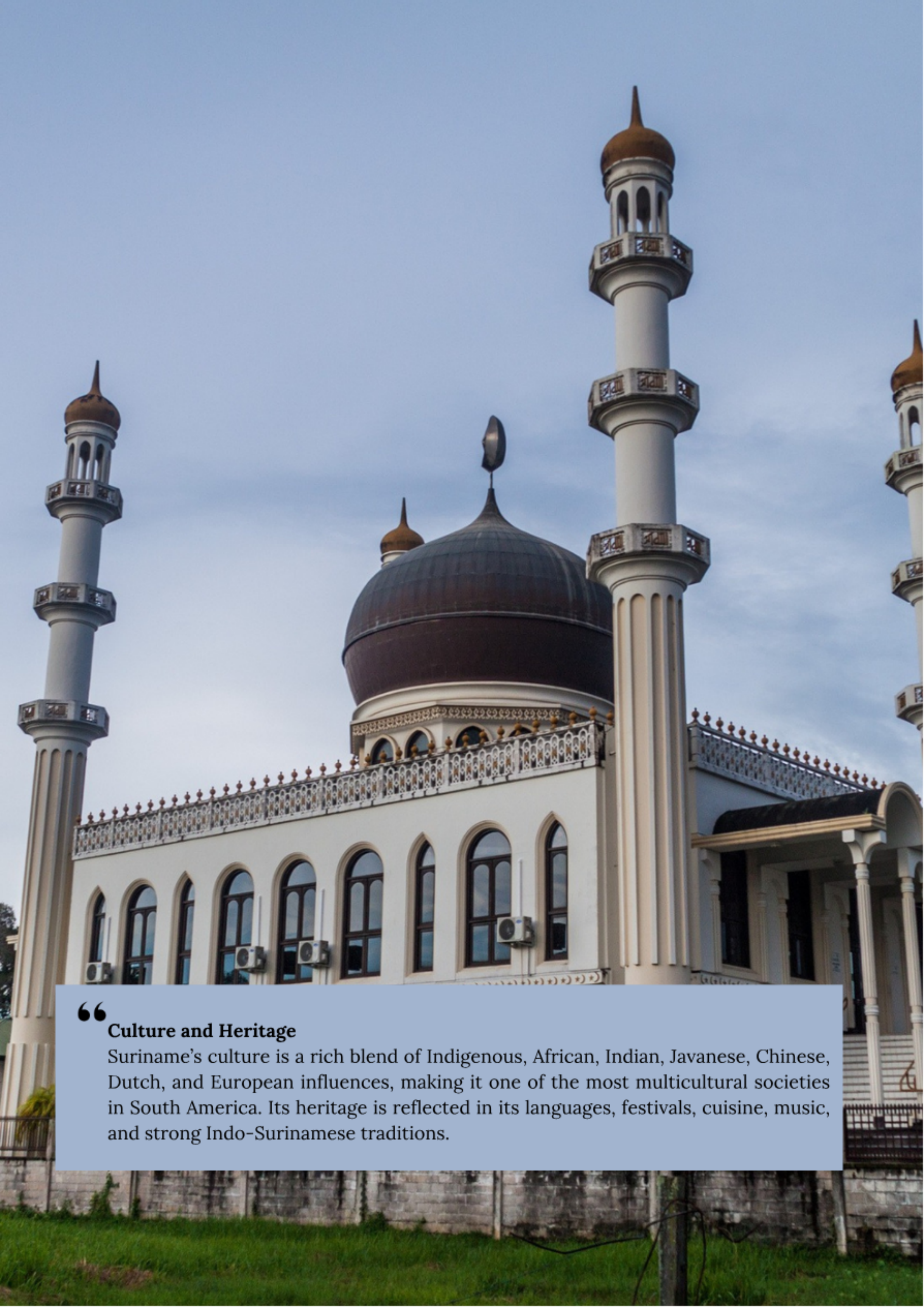
Suriname's economy is valued at approximately USD 4–5 billion in 2024, with a nominal GDP of around USD $4.4–4.5 billion and GDP per capita near USD 7,500. The economy relies heavily on mining, oil, agriculture, and forestry, with gold being the largest export contributor. Recent offshore oil discoveries have created strong future potential for economic expansion, while reforms and foreign investment are helping modernize and stabilize the economy despite inflation and fiscal challenges.

**The primary sectors contributing to the GDP are:**

✦ **Agriculture:** Includes rice, bananas, palm products, fisheries, and forestry, supporting both domestic consumption and exports.

✦ **Services:** The largest contributor, driven by trade, transport, public administration, and urban economic activity centered around Paramaribo.

✦ **Industry:** Dominated by mining, gold production, bauxite, and oil-related industries, forming the backbone of export earnings.



**Culture and Heritage**

Suriname's culture is a rich blend of Indigenous, African, Indian, Javanese, Chinese, Dutch, and European influences, making it one of the most multicultural societies in South America. Its heritage is reflected in its languages, festivals, cuisine, music, and strong Indo-Surinamese traditions.

## Bilateral Trade and Economic Ties with India

India and Suriname share warm and steadily growing bilateral ties rooted in strong historical and cultural connections, especially through the large Indo-Surinamese community. Economic cooperation between the two countries has expanded in sectors such as pharmaceuticals, agriculture, mining, renewable energy, healthcare, machinery, and ICT. India plays an important role in supporting Suriname through technical training programs like ITEC, capacity-building initiatives, and knowledge-sharing partnerships.

## Bilateral Trade with India (in USD Millions)

India–Surinamebilateral tradein FY2023–24is valued at approximately USD USD 15–30 million, reflecting a modest but steadily growing trade relationship. India exports around USD USD 13–20 million worth of goods to Suriname, mainly pharmaceuticals, automobiles, machinery, textiles, food products, and chemicals. Suriname exports about USD 10–20 million to India, including timber, minerals, seafood, rum, and agricultural goods, showing a complementary trade pattern between both economies.



## Import and Export Composition

Suriname's export economy is led by gold, oil and petroleum derivatives, aluminum, bauxite, timber, rice, and seafood, with total exports valued at around USD $1.83 billion annually. Its imports, worth approximately USD 1.5–2.0 billion, mainly consist of machinery, vehicles, petroleum products, processed food goods, and electronics. In trade with India, Suriname mainly imports medicines, machinery, textiles, and manufactured goods, while exporting timber, minerals, seafood, and selected agricultural products.

## Economic Cooperation and Investment

Economic cooperation between India and Suriname is growing across healthcare, pharmaceuticals, agriculture, mining, renewable energy, and IT training. Indian companies supply medicines, machinery, textiles, and automobiles, while Suriname offers opportunities in natural resources, forestry, and offshore oil development.

# COUNTRY PROFILE

## Country Profile of Suriname

The Republic of Suriname is the smallest sovereign state in South America by population and the only country on the continent where Dutch is the official language. Located on the north-eastern Atlantic coast of the continent, Suriname occupies a distinctive position as a Caribbean Community (CARICOM) member state that is geographically South American, culturally Caribbean and Asian-influenced, and economically oriented toward extractive commodities. For India, Suriname represents both a legacy relationship rooted in 150 years of Indian indentured migration and an emerging opportunity tied to a prospective offshore oil boom.

### Official Name and Location

Suriname's official name is the Republic of Suriname (Republiek Suriname). It is bordered by French Guiana (an overseas department of France) to the east, Guyana to the west, Brazil to the south, and the Atlantic Ocean to the north.

### Geography and Area

Suriname covers a total area of approximately 163,820 sq km, making it roughly half the size of the Indian state of Uttar Pradesh. Around 94.5 percent of the country is covered by tropical rainforest, giving Suriname one of the highest forest-cover ratios in the world and positioning it as one of only three verified carbon-negative countries globally. The coastal strip, where the vast majority of the population and economic activity is concentrated, is low-lying and highly vulnerable to flooding, while the interior is sparsely populated, forested, and home to Maroon and Indigenous communities.

### Population and Demographics

Suriname's population is estimated at approximately 617,000–654,000 (2025 estimates vary by source; World Bank and CIA World Factbook figures range from 617,000 to 654,000), making it one of the least densely populated countries in the world at roughly 4 people per sq km. Population growth is slow, and the country experiences significant net emigration, particularly to the Netherlands, its former colonial power.

Suriname is one of the most ethnically diverse countries in the world. According to the 2012 Census (the most recent comprehensive census; a new census was pending as of this paper's preparation), the population comprises: Hindustani/Indo-Surinamese (27.4%), Maroon (21.7%), Creole (15.7%), Javanese (13.7%), persons of mixed heritage (13.4%), Indigenous peoples (3.8%), and Chinese and other groups (remainder). This diversity is mirrored in religion: Hindu (approximately 22%), Protestant denominations (approximately 24%), Roman Catholic (approximately 22%), and Muslim (approximately 14%). The country's linguistic and cultural diversity also creates opportunities for stronger people-to-people, cultural, educational, and diaspora-led engagement between India and Suriname.



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## Language, Currency and Political System

- **Official language:** Dutch (the only Dutch-official-language state in South America).
- **Widely spoken languages:** Sranan Tongo (lingua franca), Sarnami Hindustani, Javanese, Surinamese English, and various Maroon and Amerindian languages.
- **Currency:** Surinamese Dollar (SRD), which replaced the Surinamese Guilder in 2004 and has experienced significant depreciation and volatility over 2020–2023 before stabilising somewhat under the IMF-backed reform programme
- **Political system:** Suriname is a presidential representative democratic republic. The President is both head of state and head of government, elected by the National Assembly (unicameral, 51 seats) for a five-year term, renewable without limit
- **Administrative divisions:** 10 districts, with Paramaribo district (the capital) as the principal centre of population, government and commerce

## Government and Current Leadership

Following the general election of 25 May 2025 in which no party won a clear majority and the National Democratic Party (NDP) and the Progressive Reform Party (VHP) finished nearly tied a six-party coalition agreement led to the National Assembly electing Dr Jennifer Geerlings-Simons (NDP) as the 11th President of Suriname and Suriname's first female head of state. She was inaugurated on 16 July 2025 for a term running to 2030, with Gregory Rusland (National Party of Suriname) as Vice President. The change in administration is significant for business planning: the new government inherits a fragile but improving fiscal position and an approaching offshore oil windfall, and its policy choices on fiscal discipline, local content, and investment facilitation will materially shape the business environment over 2026–2030.

## Independence and Historical Milestones

- 1667–1975: Dutch colonial rule as Dutch Guiana (with a brief British interlude in the early 1800s)
- 1863: Abolition of slavery, followed by a mandatory ten-year transition period
- 1873–1916: Arrival of approximately 34,000 Indian indentured labourers, followed by Javanese indentured labourers post-1916, fundamentally shaping Suriname's demographic and cultural composition
- 25 November 1975: Independence from the Netherlands
- 1980–1987 and 1990–1991: Periods of military rule under Dési Bouterse, followed by return to constitutional democracy
- 2004: Currency redenomination introduction of the Surinamese Dollar (SRD)
- 2020: Chan Santokhi (VHP) elected President; onset of IMF-supported fiscal reform following a 2022 sovereign debt default
- 2024: Final Investment Decision on the GranMorgu offshore oil project



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